

25,000 metric tons

The amount of greenhouse gases produced in a year by about 4,500 passenger vehicles

DIGITAL LIFE



A critical look at Green-Tech

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One thing that is impossible to dispute is that the western anti-carbon dioxide (CO₂) obsession, based on an assumption that a human driven (anthropogenic) increase in atmospheric CO₂ is dangerously affecting the climate, deflects attention away from many other environmental issues. There are many such important issues with which we need to deal, but just looking at pollution for now, there is nitrogen dioxide, sulphur dioxide, benzene (carcinogenic, apparently), lead, mercury, toxic substances released from the dumping of electronic waste, biochemical and pharmaceutical waste — those are just the first few that come to mind; the complete list must be huge.

One hears much less nowadays of people talking of rescuing the rain forests, saving the whales or other issues; in fact, proper care for the environment seems to have been swept away by the mantra: "Save the planet; reduce your carbon footprint". The view put forward by the likes of Al Gore and the IPCC (Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change) is that anthropogenic carbon dioxide is causing the planet to warm up dangerously. If this view is wrong, then not only are populations being forced to spend ridiculous amounts of money on trying to reduce carbon emissions,

but great damage is actually being done to the environment by deflecting attention away from genuine environmental issues. (Who benefits from this, one might ask?)

Carbon dioxide is the very basis of the food chain of life on this planet. Plants love it. One scientist (Dr. Will Happer) recently reported to the US Congress that the Earth was in a "CO₂ famine now." Not a popular view among politicians that, but since atmospheric levels of CO₂ started to increase towards the beginning of the last century, plant growth has increased by around 30 per cent, on average. In particular, crops have benefited. Not bad on

this hungry planet. Also, laboratory tests show that increased levels of carbon dioxide allow plants to use less water, and so semi-arid areas have particularly benefited from this, and would continue to do so if levels increased further. In fact, laboratory tests suggest that for life, for the biosphere, the optimum concentration of CO₂ in our atmosphere would be about three times what it is at present. It has been up to 10 times present levels. And yet there are many green activists who want us to reduce CO₂ levels dramatically. They seem to have forgotten just from where the use of the word green came! So, why?

Many hardware companies are touting "green" benefits for their products, and when questioned this seems usually to mean reduced energy needs and an assumed benefit regarding climate change. In this article we take a critical look at the science involved, and suggest possibly a better way of helping the environment.

Real pollution: e-waste piling up in Guiyu, China.
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